

ANOUSHKA SHANKAR
Stolen Moments

What do you get when you put two of the most exciting women in the Hindustani classical fusion space together in one studio? An instant classic. 'Stolen Moments', which features contributions from German experimental composer Nils Frahm, is the lead single off Anoushka Shankar's upcoming mini-album *Chapter I: Forever, For Now*, produced by Pakistani-American sensation Arooj Aftab. Shankar's sitar weaves hazy, reverb-laden loops that shift and mutate as they snake their way across a minimal-yet-expansive soundscape, pulling the listener into a liminal space beyond time.

DHANJI, *Ruab*



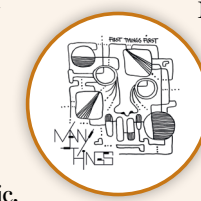
One of the most exciting Indian hip-hop releases in the past couple of years, Dhanji's debut album *Ruab* incorporates funk, hip-hop, blues, art-rock and lo-fi beats into an ambitious avant-garde concept album about the conflict between art and capital. Aided by a coterie of beatmakers and collaborators—including Mumbai underground star Gravity and Seedhe Maut's Encore ABJ—the Ahmedabad rapper shifts between sounds and styles with ease. With lyrics that reference everything from Ice Cube to Dev Anand, *Ruab* is a unique and challenging record that pushes the Indian hip-hop scene into rewarding new spaces.



Southern Sounds

Chennai-based band Many Things is out with their debut album, *First Things First*

Aravind Murali and Maarten Visser have known each other for more than 20 years. Both composers, Visser on the saxophone and Aravind on bass, joined Manukrishnan on drums to form the band they call Many Things. The name, like their music with minimal production, rests on what-they-play-is-what-you-get. They are a cross-genre instrumental trio from Chennai hovering around jazz with an occasional leap into classical rock and funk and they are out with their album *First Things First* (available on Bandcamp and streaming platforms). Visser says he and Aravind had the idea of doing something in jazz, but it never happened until now. Before the pandemic, Manukrishnan and Visser mulled over the idea when Manu and Aravind had not even met. It was a liberated way of writing music for each one of them. For Visser, it was all about a band that he would want to play in.



Manu has lived in Chennai for about 18 years and had followed Visser and Aravind's works from a distance. Himself part of bands like Jatayu, Chaos and the Casteless Collective, it took some time—years—for him to say hi to either of them. Visser and Manu got closer when Jatayu needed an arranger for the western portions of their album. But nothing transpired immediately. There was the pandemic, then Manu, as he puts it, "disappeared" for a while and, finally, at the end of 2021, there was alchemy. In 2022, they played together and performed live.

For Aravind, it's a reinvention he refers to as 2.0. "I've been on the studio side of things, so playing live is still new to me," he says. They are not signed to a label so it's still independent music for three experienced artists. "I never felt part of an indie scene," says Visser. "I am part of the Indian jazz community. It might be small and marginal but encompasses the country." However, Many Things would make Visser part of that indie culture, and he thinks of it as a reboot and in various ways for all of them. Their music involves minimal to no production. They did a few takes in the studio and soon realised that the presence of an audience is integral to their music and that's an atmosphere they want to recreate. They retain imperfections, if any, and maintain the energy of a jamming session. "It's not necessary, the production. We just play and record it with our sound engineer Jaishankar." Many Things doesn't like to be pigeonholed into a genre. Manu says, "We may be part of the indie scene, but we don't want to box ourselves into that jazz corner." As Visser puts it, "It's not an interesting question, 'is the music this or that?' So, if we have two sets of things, then we have Many Things." ■

Aditya Shrikrishna